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- Efforts of ambitious second-rung leaders to damage each other is a major **THREAT**.
- The BJP's famed discipline is a thing of the past and chaos reigns at every level in party.
- Not all NDA allies are equally trustworthy and some like Nitish Kumar may overreach.

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ment, Advani is the Leader with a capital L, and the campaign he leads is truly presidential in style, partly inspired by—who else?—Barack Obama. Campaign literature with “Advani for PM” or the cardboard cult of “Determined Leader, Decisive Government” is not the only manifestation of it. The entire campaign has become a kind of referendum on Advani. It is virtually Advani versus the rest. He is the message as well as the messenger. So, before he gives himself to Sudoku, you ask him: “Do you think the verdict too will be presidential? Will it be a vote for Advani rather than one for BJP?” First he is defensive: “We have a parliamentary system”. “But the entire campaign centres on you.” Maybe it's not the time to sound tentative or apologetic about something he can take full credit for. “Nothing wrong about it”, he admits, adding, “and it's nothing new too.” “Since the days of Nehru, it's the leader of the party who has been leading the election campaign.” Perhaps he is reluctant to sound too presidential before reaching there.

Still, he doesn't want to reach there as a traveller weighed down by the rusted baggage of the past, though he cannot completely discard it either. The past is a narrative of mutations and makeovers. At every way station, be it Ayodhya or Delhi or Karachi, the traveller has acquired an identity that is incompatible with the Left-liberal drawing rooms of India. Today the Advani on the stump, or the Advani in conversation, marks another defining shift in his evolutionary story, and the first sign of it is not the iPhone he carries. It is evident in his vocabulary. Ask him about the big message and he goes unabashedly digital. The moderniser is on full display. “The biggest contribution of science in the 20th Century was Internet connectivity. We want every boy, every girl, in this country to be computer-literate.” Anticipating the danger of the leader getting lost in an electronic labyrinth, Deepak Chopra, his trusted aide and constant companion in election tours, gives a copy of the party's revision, ‘Transforming Bharat’, which has chapters like Digital Highways, e-Governance for Good Governance and e-Development for All. Expanding on Vajpayee's call for “Let a Hundred Bangalores Bloom”, it promises an e-heaven where everything—from education to healthcare to individual identity to national security—will be digitally perfect. It even promises a corruption-free India.

“The youth dividend is our strength, after all,” he says. “But you are not so young.”

“We have become obsessed with age. History is replete with the old who brought radical change to the world. Leaders like Gandhi and Jayaprakash Narayan (JP).”

It's not that he has forgotten the young, including some obvious ones. “So you are saying that you are growing wiser?” He tells a story about Vinoba Bhave, who learned Arabic at the age of 53 because he wanted to read the Quran in its original text. The moral of the story is: Advani is growing younger, though not exactly in Benjamin Button style. Still, it is the curious case of a man who has migrated